Middle Eastern), explained to Sir Arthur Hirtzel of the India Office in January 1918:

If America had not come into the war, if the Russian Revolution had not taken place, if the idea of no annexations had not taken root, if the world spirit of this time was the world spirit of 1887... [But now] we have to look at the problem through entirely new spectacles.[6]

How many other officials in the British government recognised the differences of the post-war world, however, remains to be seen. In the meantime, the period from 1918 to 1919 was one in which Britain, emerging from the battlefields, had to start adjusting its foreign policy from a war-time to a peace-time footing. It was, therefore, a time when some of the greatest debates took place within government, as officials thrashed out their ideas about the empire's future.

Two Voices

One particular problem with Britain's relationship with southern Asia and the Middle East in this period is that there was serious interdepartmental friction and overlapping function when it came to the creation and administration of policy.[7] And part of the issue lay with the role which India was to play in this region of the world. Throughout the history of the Raj, there had been debate about India's contribution to the maintenance of the empire. In 1920, the issue appeared to have been resolved when both the Indian and Home governments agreed that:

Apart from such 'special cases' as might arise...India should bear primary financial responsibility for those geographical regions in which she had a 'direct and substantial interest'. Included among such regions were Egypt